

Olympiad Test Paper — Social Science (Class 7) — Paper 3

Chapter 5: The Rise of Empires

Paper 3 — (progressively harder)

Subject	Social Science (NCERT Class 7)
Chapter	5 — The Rise of Empires
Total Questions	60 (Multiple Choice, single correct)
Maximum Marks	240
Suggested Time	90 minutes

Marking scheme: +4 for each correct answer · -1 for each wrong answer · 0 if unattempted.

Instructions: Each question has four options (A), (B), (C), (D); exactly one is correct. Prakrit is a spoken language while Brahmi is the script it was written in; Alexander reached only the northwest and never conquered all of India; an emperor ruled distant lands through officials, tributaries and satraps rather than directly governing every village; and the Kalinga war led Ashoka toward Dhamma, not the other way round. Do not write on this paper — mark answers on your answer sheet.

1. A historian writes: "In a kingdom the king's writ runs to its borders; in an empire several kings still sit on their thrones, but all bow to one supreme overlord." The single feature this contrast pins down is that an empire is built by:

- (A) layering many subordinate kingdoms beneath one paramount ruler who holds supreme power over them all
- (B) abolishing every local king so that only the emperor's officials remain
- (C) being wealthier and better armed than any ordinary kingdom
- (D) covering a larger area of land than any single kingdom could

2. Assertion (A): An emperor often let a defeated king keep his throne. Reason (R): Allowing a defeated king to rule as a tributary let the emperor control distant lands without governing every village himself. Choose the best evaluation.

- (A) Both A and R are true but R does not explain A
- (B) Both A and R are true and R correctly explains A
- (C) A is true but R is false
- (D) A is false but R is true

3. Tribute, a strong army, administration, communication networks, a thriving economy and support for art and learning are the supports an empire must maintain. Which pairing

shows the support and the problem it chiefly solves?

- (A) tribute — defending the frontier against invading armies
- (B) support for art and learning — collecting taxes from far provinces
- (C) communication networks — moving orders, troops and news quickly across great distances
- (D) a thriving economy — choosing the next emperor fairly

4. Why does the chapter argue that a strong army, though essential, cannot by itself hold an empire together?

- (A) An army is forbidden from entering the empire's distant provinces
- (B) Soldiers were unpaid volunteers, so cost was never an issue
- (C) An army is hugely expensive, so without a thriving economy and steady tax revenue it cannot be paid or maintained
- (D) An empire's borders were defended by tributary kings, not by the emperor's army at all

5. An emperor insists on a common currency and standard weights and measures across his lands. The deepest reason, as the chapter explains it, is that this:

- (A) removes any need for the emperor to keep an army
- (B) makes the emperor personally wealthier than every subordinate king
- (C) replaces the need for officials to administer the provinces
- (D) lets distant regions trade with one another and lets the state tax that trade under one shared system

6. Two distant provinces of an empire use different coins, different weights and different measures. Following the chapter's logic, the most likely consequence is that:

- (A) the empire's army automatically grows stronger
- (B) trade between the provinces and tax collection across them both become harder, weakening the empire's economy
- (C) the emperor can rule each province directly without officials
- (D) the provinces immediately produce more food and iron

7. Source: "The weavers' shreni fixed fair prices, shared news of demand, elected an honest head, and judged its members' quarrels by its own rules." What does this passage best establish about guilds in this period?

- (A) They were policed day to day by the king's soldiers
- (B) Their only purpose was to gather tribute for the emperor
- (C) They were largely self-governing bodies whose ordered working helped trade and the wider economy flourish
- (D) They were tiny family workshops that followed no shared rules

8. A wise king deliberately leaves the guilds to make and follow their own rules. The best explanation of his motive is that:

- (A) he had no power whatsoever to interfere with them
- (B) the law forbade any king from touching matters of trade
- (C) orderly, self-running guilds kept production, trade and therefore tax revenue flowing smoothly
- (D) guilds paid no taxes, so they were of no interest to him

9. India's two great long-distance arteries of trade in this period were the Uttarapatha and the Dakshinapatha. Their chief value to a rising power lay in the fact that they:

- (A) marked the fixed permanent borders of every Indian empire
- (B) were sea routes that gave India command of ocean trade
- (C) were used only by Ashoka to carry his edicts to the provinces
- (D) linked far regions, carrying goods, news and troops, so whoever controlled them gained wealth and reach

10. Why does the chapter treat a thriving economy as the foundation on which the other supports of empire rest?

- (A) A strong economy removes the need for tribute from subordinate kings
- (B) Wealth from trade and taxes is what pays for the army, the officials and the communication networks an empire needs
- (C) Economic strength alone, with no army, was enough to hold an empire
- (D) The economy mattered only because coins were the empire's finest art

11. Of the sixteen mahajanapadas, Magadha alone rose to imperial greatness. Which combination of advantages best explains this, according to the chapter?

- (A) great seaports, a powerful navy and command of ocean trade
- (B) gold mines and control over the distant Silk Road
- (C) high snowy mountains and a protective cold desert frontier
- (D) fertile Ganga-plain soil, nearby iron ore, forests for war-elephants, and rivers easing trade and troop movement

12. Iron from the hills near Magadha strengthened it in two distinct ways at once. These were:

- (A) iron ships for a navy and iron coins for trade
- (B) iron temples for worship and iron pillars for edicts
- (C) iron sold abroad for gold and iron paid as tribute
- (D) iron ploughs that raised food output, and iron weapons that armed a powerful military

13. Mahapadma Nanda is described as already building features of imperial, not merely royal, rule. Which action best shows this shift toward empire?

- (A) writing the Arthashastra to set out the science of statecraft
- (B) carving moral edicts onto rock surfaces and stone pillars

(C) defeating Alexander's army on the banks of the Indus

(D) unifying many kingdoms under his control while issuing coins and keeping a vast army

14. Cause and effect: the last Nanda king, Dhana Nanda, was immensely rich, yet his subjects' loyalty drained away. The chapter links this loss of loyalty chiefly to the fact that he:

(A) oppressed and heavily over-taxed his people

(B) emptied the treasury by giving its wealth away

(C) refused to mint any coins for trade (D) surrendered his throne to a Greek satrap

15. Around 326 BCE Alexander of Macedonia reached the northwest of India. He arrived there only after first overrunning which great power?

(A) the Nanda empire of Magadha (B) the Maurya empire of Pataliputra

(C) the Roman Empire of the Mediterranean (D) the Persian (Achaemenid) Empire

16. A classmate insists, "Alexander conquered the whole of India." The most accurate correction is that he:

(A) was defeated in battle and killed by King Porus

(B) conquered the far south but left the north untouched

(C) reached only the northwest and turned back when his weary soldiers refused to advance further

(D) never actually set foot outside Greece

17. Assertion (A): Alexander's direct hold on Indian land was brief and shallow. Reason (R): He left weak Greek governors behind and opened new contacts, rather than firmly ruling Indian territory himself. Choose the best evaluation.

(A) Both A and R are true but R does not explain A

(B) Both A and R are true and R correctly explains A

(C) A is true but R is false

(D) A is false but R is true

18. The chapter says Chandragupta could expand so rapidly in the northwest partly because of conditions left by Alexander's departure and death. Which condition helped him most there?

(A) weak Greek satraps he could defeat or absorb

(B) a strong, united Greek army still guarding the northwest

(C) a peace treaty Ashoka had already signed for the region

(D) the lifelong loyalty of the Nanda soldiers to him

19. Around 321 BCE Chandragupta Maurya founded the Maurya empire. The chapter attributes his success chiefly to:

(A) being crowned emperor of India by Alexander himself

(B) overthrowing the unpopular Nandas with the guidance of Kautilya

- (C) inheriting the throne peacefully from his grandson Ashoka
- (D) marrying into the Persian royal house to gain its armies

20. Kautilya, the mentor who helped Chandragupta to power, is also known by which other name?

- (A) Chanakya (Vishnugupta)
- (B) Megasthenes
- (C) Panini
- (D) Porus

21. The Arthashastra is best described as a treatise on:

- (A) Buddhist religious doctrine and monastic rules
- (B) the science of governance, statecraft and economics
- (C) court poetry composed in praise of the emperor
- (D) a collection of Ashoka's moral edicts

22. Kautilya's saptanga likens the state to a body with seven limbs. Which list correctly names them?

- (A) king, queen, priests, merchants, farmers, soldiers and slaves
- (B) the king, the ministers, the territory and people, the fort, the treasury, the army, and the allies
- (C) land, sea, forests, mines, rivers, hills and cities
- (D) army, navy, cavalry, forts, coins, roads and temples

23. Why does Kautilya insist that a strong state needs all seven limbs working together rather than a powerful king alone?

- (A) Because seven was regarded as a lucky number by the Mauryas
- (B) Because a state is like a body: if any one limb is weak, the whole is endangered
- (C) Because tradition forbade a king from keeping any treasury
- (D) Because the king was not permitted to command the army himself

24. In the saptanga the treasury and the army appear as two separate limbs. The best reason for keeping them distinct is that:

- (A) the treasury and the army were never used at the same time
- (B) the army was always paid in grain rather than from the treasury
- (C) they perform different functions — one funds the state's needs while the other defends and enforces its authority
- (D) the treasury belonged to the guilds while the army belonged to the king

25. Match each figure to his role — Chandragupta Maurya, Kautilya, Megasthenes:

- (A) founder of the Maurya empire; mentor and author of the Arthashastra; Greek envoy who visited the Mauryan court
- (B) Greek envoy; founder of the empire; author of the Arthashastra
- (C) author of the Arthashastra; Greek envoy; founder of the empire
- (D) mentor and author of the Arthashastra; the last Nanda king; founder of the empire

26. Megasthenes is valuable to historians chiefly because, as the Greek envoy to the Mauryan court, he:

- (A) composed the Arthashastra setting out Mauryan statecraft
- (B) carved Ashoka's edicts into rock across the empire
- (C) left an outsider's written account of Mauryan India in his work, the Indica
- (D) founded the Maurya dynasty after defeating the Nandas

27. Bindusara fits into the Mauryan succession as the:

- (A) mentor of Chandragupta who wrote the Arthashastra
- (B) Greek envoy sent to the Mauryan court
- (C) founder of the dynasty who overthrew the Nandas
- (D) son of Chandragupta and the father of Ashoka, ruling between them

28. An emperor could not personally watch over every distant province. The Mauryan answer to this was to:

- (A) abolish provinces and let each village rule itself entirely
- (B) divide the empire into provinces run by governors and officials answerable to the centre
- (C) leave every region to the guilds to govern as they pleased
- (D) have the emperor tour every village in person each year

29. The dhamma-mahamatras appointed by Ashoka were officials whose special task was to:

- (A) command the cavalry on the empire's frontiers
- (B) collect tribute from the empire's subordinate kings
- (C) carve the Brahmi letters of the edicts into the rock
- (D) spread and oversee the practice of Dhamma among the people

30. Mauryan administration is described as using a network of spies. The best explanation of why a far-flung empire would value such a network is that it:

- (A) let the centre learn what was happening in distant provinces and check on its own officials
- (B) removed any need to keep an army at all
- (C) replaced the common currency used across the empire
- (D) took the place of governors in running the provinces

31. Taxation mattered to the Mauryan state above all because it:

- (A) was the emperor's way of punishing disloyal provinces
- (B) supplied the steady revenue needed to pay the army, officials and the works of the empire
- (C) existed only to enrich the guilds of the cities
- (D) replaced the need for any trade or economy

- 32.** At the height of his reign Ashoka's empire stretched over nearly the whole subcontinent. The notable region it did NOT include was:
- (A) the Ganga plains around Pataliputra
 - (B) the far south of the peninsula
 - (C) the northwest reaching into parts of Afghanistan
 - (D) the eastern lands including modern Bangladesh
- 33.** The bloody war that became the turning point of Ashoka's life was fought against:
- (A) the Persians in the northwest
 - (B) Porus and the Pauravas in Punjab
 - (C) Kalinga, in modern Odisha
 - (D) the Nandas of Magadha
- 34.** A student claims, "Ashoka attacked Kalinga in order to spread Buddhism." Why does this reverse the real sequence?
- (A) Kalinga had already become Buddhist before Ashoka attacked it
 - (B) Ashoka never actually fought a war at Kalinga at all
 - (C) He attacked to enlarge his empire, and it was the horror of the bloodshed afterwards that turned him toward Dhamma
 - (D) Buddhist teaching forbade any king from ever waging war
- 35.** We can be confident Ashoka was genuinely shaken by the Kalinga war chiefly because:
- (A) he openly recorded his remorse in his own edicts
 - (B) Megasthenes described his grief in the Indica
 - (C) Kautilya wrote about it in the Arthashastra
 - (D) a later king built a temple to commemorate it
- 36.** Ashoka's idea of Dhamma is best understood as:
- (A) a brand-new religion meant to replace Buddhism
 - (B) a code of moral and ethical conduct — honesty, non-violence, respect for others and doing one's duties truthfully
 - (C) a special tax demanded from the tributary kings
 - (D) the science of warfare and battlefield strategy
- 37.** Ashoka is praised as a "great communicator" because he spread his message of Dhamma mainly by:
- (A) sending soldiers to recite his words in every village
 - (B) printing books to be placed in every household
 - (C) engraving edicts on rocks and stone pillars across the empire
 - (D) building a single great central temple for all to visit
- 38.** Why would Ashoka have his edicts cut into rock and stone pillars rather than written on paper or cloth?
- (A) Stone happened to be cheaper than every other material
 - (B) Stone is permanent and public, surviving weather and the passing of centuries

- (C) Paper and cloth had not yet been invented anywhere on earth
- (D) The Brahmi script could only ever be carved into stone

39. Ashoka's edicts were composed mainly in the ____ language and written in the ____ script.

- (A) Sanskrit; Devanagari
- (B) Greek; Latin
- (C) Prakrit; Brahmi
- (D) Tamil; Brahmi

40. A classmate says, "Prakrit and Brahmi are just two names for the same thing." The correct correction is that:

- (A) Brahmi is the spoken language and Prakrit is the script
- (B) both are scripts that only the Greeks ever used
- (C) both are languages and neither is a script at all
- (D) Prakrit is a language people spoke, while Brahmi is a script, a way of writing it down

41. Why might Ashoka have chosen the everyday Prakrit language rather than the more refined Sanskrit for his edicts?

- (A) So that ordinary people could understand his messages directly
- (B) Because Sanskrit had not yet been invented in his time
- (C) Because Prakrit was the only language that could be carved on stone
- (D) Because Prakrit was a secret tongue kept from commoners

42. Beyond Ashoka's edicts, the Brahmi script holds lasting importance because it is:

- (A) the ancestor from which most of today's Indian scripts descend
- (B) identical to the modern Roman alphabet of Europe
- (C) a script that has never been deciphered by scholars
- (D) a spoken language used only inside the Mauryan court

43. The Mauryan artwork later chosen as independent India's national emblem is the:

- (A) Great Stupa at Sanchi
- (B) rock-cut elephant at Dhauri
- (C) Lion Capital of the pillar at Sarnath
- (D) terracotta dancing figure

44. On the "Lion Capital of Sarnath," the word capital refers to the:

- (A) capital city from which the Mauryas ruled
- (B) treasury where the empire kept its wealth
- (C) main edict inscribed along the pillar's shaft
- (D) carved top, or crowning head, of the stone column

45. Ashoka raised his lion pillar specifically at Sarnath because Sarnath was the place where:

- (A) Ashoka was crowned emperor of the Mauryas
- (B) the Kalinga war was fought to its bloody end

- (C) Chandragupta finally defeated the last of the Nandas
- (D) the Buddha delivered his first teaching

46. The wheel placed at the centre of India's national flag, the dharmachakra, is drawn from Mauryan art and symbolises:

- (A) the wheel of a Mauryan war chariot
- (B) the empire's web of trade routes
- (C) the wheel of dharma, representing righteous law and the Buddha's teaching
- (D) the sun worshipped by the Mauryan kings

47. Chronology: place these in correct order — (i) Mahapadma Nanda founds the Nanda dynasty, (ii) Alexander reaches the northwest of India, (iii) Chandragupta founds the Maurya empire, (iv) Ashoka fights the Kalinga war.

- (A) (ii), (i), (iii), (iv)
- (B) (iii), (i), (ii), (iv)
- (C) (i), (iii), (ii), (iv)
- (D) (i), (ii), (iii), (iv)

48. Comparing the Nanda and Maurya states, which single statement is most accurate?

- (A) The Nandas first unified Magadha's lands, and the Mauryas then took over and expanded far further
- (B) The Mauryas began the empire and the Nandas later destroyed it
- (C) The Nandas carved edicts on pillars while the Mauryas carved none
- (D) The Nandas and Mauryas ruled at the very same time as rivals

49. A satrap, the kind of governor associated with Alexander's arrangements, was best described as:

- (A) an appointed governor left in charge of a province on behalf of the overlord
- (B) the tribute paid each year to the emperor
- (C) a guild of moneylenders in the great cities
- (D) a soldier in the personal bodyguard of the king

50. Both a tributary king and a satrap let an overlord control distant land without being present everywhere. The key difference is that a tributary:

- (A) is an appointed official with no realm, unlike the satrap
- (B) always rules a larger territory than the overlord himself
- (C) is by rule always Greek, while a satrap is always Indian
- (D) keeps his own throne while paying tribute, whereas a satrap is an appointed governor with no kingdom of his own

51. The Maurya empire is said to have ended around 185 BCE. Compared with Ashoka's death in 232 BCE, this means the empire collapsed:

- (A) within about half a century of his death
- (B) roughly two centuries after his death
- (C) within a single year of his death
- (D) more than three hundred years after his death

52. The chapter calls empires "fragile." The reason that best captures this fragility is that they:

- (A) were in truth never very large in the first place
- (B) kept no armies and so could not defend themselves
- (C) rest on force and tribute, so distant regions break away once the centre weakens
- (D) always refused to collect tribute from their provinces

53. Which situation, by the chapter's reasoning, would MOST tempt a distant province to break away from an empire?

- (A) a weak emperor following a strong one, combined with heavier tribute demands
- (B) a strong emperor following another strong emperor
- (C) lower tribute demands during a long stretch of peace
- (D) the building of better roads linking the province to the capital

54. Suppose a new empire has a strong army, capable officials, a common currency and good roads, but neglects "support for art and learning." Using the chapter's framework, its most likely weakness is that it:

- (A) cannot collect any tribute from its provinces at all
- (B) lacks the shared culture that helps bind its many different peoples together
- (C) will find all its soldiers gone within a single year
- (D) is unable to build even one fort anywhere in its lands

55. Suppose Ashoka had felt no remorse after Kalinga and simply kept conquering. The chapter's logic suggests that:

- (A) the Maurya empire would have collapsed that very year
- (B) he might have waged further aggressive wars, and his Dhamma edicts would never have been composed
- (C) the Brahmi script would never have been deciphered later
- (D) Chandragupta would somehow have lost his throne

56. A historian finds an Ashokan edict, in Prakrit and Brahmi, near a far frontier of the empire. The spread of such edicts is most useful for telling us:

- (A) roughly how far Ashoka's empire and influence extended
- (B) the exact year in which Alexander was born
- (C) the day-to-day price of iron in Magadha's markets
- (D) the precise number of guilds in each Mauryan city

57. Taking the chapter as a whole, the deepest lesson it draws about empires is that:

- (A) once founded, an empire endures forever unchanged
- (B) an empire needs only a strong emperor and nothing more
- (C) building an empire is hard but holding one together is harder still, so even the greatest eventually decline
- (D) tribute by itself, without army or administration, is enough to rule

58. Alexander defeated King Porus of the Pauravas in battle near the Indus, yet soon turned homeward. The immediate cause given for his retreat was that:

- (A) Chandragupta Maurya defeated him in open battle
- (B) the Nandas bought him off with a large tribute to leave
- (C) he had completely run out of weapons and supplies
- (D) his weary soldiers refused to march any further east

59. The chapter notes that the Maurya empire could not be run by the emperor alone but needed a large body of officials. The best explanation of why such an administration was indispensable is that it:

- (A) carried the centre's authority into provinces too distant for the emperor to govern in person
- (B) made the strong army and the treasury completely unnecessary
- (C) allowed the emperor to abolish taxes throughout the empire
- (D) existed mainly to compose poetry in praise of the emperor

60. Megasthenes' Indica and Ashoka's rock edicts are both used by historians, but they differ in nature. The clearest difference is that the Indica is:

- (A) a religious scripture, while the edicts are works of poetry
- (B) written in Brahmi, while the edicts were written in Greek
- (C) the founding charter of the empire, while the edicts ended it
- (D) an outsider's later account of Mauryan India, while the edicts are the ruler's own words inscribed for his people

Solutions — Social Science (Class 7), Chapter 5: The Rise of Empires — Paper 3

Paper 3 — (progressively harder)

Marking: +4 correct, –1 wrong, 0 unattempted. Maximum marks **240**.

Answer Key

Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans
1	A	11	D	21	B	31	B	41	A	51	A
2	B	12	D	22	B	32	B	42	A	52	C
3	C	13	D	23	B	33	C	43	C	53	A
4	C	14	A	24	C	34	C	44	D	54	B
5	D	15	D	25	A	35	A	45	D	55	B
6	B	16	C	26	C	36	B	46	C	56	A
7	C	17	B	27	D	37	C	47	D	57	C
8	C	18	A	28	B	38	B	48	A	58	D
9	D	19	B	29	D	39	C	49	A	59	A
10	B	20	A	30	A	40	D	50	D	60	D

Answer-key distribution: A = 15, B = 15, C = 15, D = 15.

Worked Solutions

1. (A) The defining mark of an empire is the layering of authority: subordinate kings keep their thrones but acknowledge one paramount overlord. Empires did not usually wipe out every local ruler; many were left in place as tributaries precisely so they could be governed at a distance. Greater wealth, a bigger army or more land may accompany an empire but are consequences, not the essential structural difference from a kingdom.

2. (B) Defeated kings were frequently left on their thrones, and the reason is exactly that an emperor could not personally govern every distant region; ruling through a tributary who paid tribute was the practical solution. So both statements are true and the reason directly accounts for the practice. The claim that the reason fails to explain it, or that either statement is false, misreads how empires managed vast territory.

3. (C) Communication networks exist to overcome distance, carrying commands, soldiers and information swiftly across the empire. Tribute is a source of wealth, not a means of frontier defence; that is the army's job. Patronage of art and learning binds peoples

culturally but does not collect taxes, and a thriving economy funds the state rather than selecting rulers. Empires had no elections, so no support exists to 'choose' an emperor.

4. (C) Maintaining a large standing army drains the treasury, so it depends on a flourishing economy and reliable taxation to fund it; an army without money soon collapses. There was no rule barring the army from provinces, soldiers were not unpaid volunteers, and while tributaries had forces of their own the emperor still kept his own army. The point is the army's dependence on economic strength.

5. (D) Standard money, weights and measures stitch a far-flung economy together: goods can move and be valued everywhere, and the state can assess and collect taxes uniformly. It does not abolish the army or the administration, both of which remain essential, and its purpose is shared prosperity and revenue rather than the emperor's personal hoard.

6. (B) Without shared money and measures, merchants cannot easily value or exchange goods across provinces and the state cannot tax trade evenly, so commerce and revenue both suffer. A weaker economy does not strengthen the army, ease direct rule, or boost food and iron output. The chapter treats a common currency as a unifier; its absence fragments the economy.

7. (C) Fixing prices, electing a head and settling disputes internally are hallmarks of self-government, and such order helped trade thrive. The passage shows no soldiers running the guild day to day, and guilds existed to organise craft and commerce, not merely to collect tribute. Far from being rule-less family shops, the shreni operated by its own clear regulations.

8. (C) By letting guilds govern themselves, a king kept the economy humming, which in turn fed his treasury through taxes on prosperous trade. It is not that he was powerless or legally barred from trade; rather, light-touch oversight served his revenue interest. Guilds and their members were indeed taxed, which is why their prosperity mattered to him.

9. (D) The Uttarapatha and Dakshinapatha were overland routes connecting distant regions; controlling them meant taxing rich flows of goods and moving armies and information. They were not borders, and they were land routes rather than ocean lanes. Ashoka's edicts came centuries later and were not the reason these trade arteries mattered.

10. (B) Armies, officials and roads all cost money, and that money comes from a flourishing economy and the taxes it yields, so economic strength underpins the rest. A strong economy does not make tribute pointless, nor can wealth alone hold an empire without force and administration. Coins were a tool of the economy, not the empire's prized artwork.

11. (D) Magadha's edge was a bundle of local advantages: rich farmland feeding a large population, iron for tools and weapons, elephant-bearing forests, and the Ganga and Son for cheap transport. It was an inland power, not a naval one, so seaports and ocean trade

are wrong; it did not rely on gold mines or the Silk Road, nor on mountains and desert, which were not its setting.

12. (D) Iron tools such as ploughs let farmers clear and work the heavy Ganga soil, boosting food, while iron weapons equipped a strong army; the same resource thus aided both economy and military. Magadha was not a naval power building iron ships, edict pillars came later under Ashoka, and the chapter does not credit iron exports or iron tribute as the source of its rise.

13. (D) Welding several kingdoms into one realm, minting coins and maintaining a huge army are imperial-scale acts, marking the Nandas as the first to push Magadha toward empire. The Arthashastra was Kautilya's work under the Mauryas, edicts on rock and pillar were Ashoka's, and the Nandas did not defeat Alexander, who never advanced as far as Magadha.

14. (A) Dhana Nanda's wealth came at his people's expense through oppression and crushing taxes, which is why loyalty collapsed and why Chandragupta found support to overthrow him. He did not impoverish himself by giving the treasury away, he was not noted for refusing to issue coins, and he never handed his throne to a Greek; he was ousted by Chandragupta and Kautilya.

15. (D) Alexander's eastward march carried him through and over the Persian Empire before he ever touched Indian soil in the northwest. He never reached or defeated the Nandas in distant Magadha, the Maurya empire did not yet exist (Chandragupta founded it a few years later), and Rome lay far to the west and was never conquered by him.

16. (C) Alexander penetrated only the northwest of the subcontinent and then withdrew because his exhausted troops mutinied against going deeper. He defeated Porus rather than being killed by him, he never reached the south, and he certainly did campaign far beyond Greece. The trap is imagining a total conquest that never happened.

17. (B) Alexander's territorial grip was indeed thin and short-lived, and the reason is precisely that he installed weak satraps and opened contacts instead of consolidating direct rule; soon after, those weak governors were swept aside. Both statements are true and the reason explains the assertion. Treating either as false ignores that his real impact on India was indirect.

18. (A) Alexander left behind feeble Greek governors, and after his death their hold crumbled, giving Chandragupta easy gains in the northwest. A strong united Greek army would have blocked him, no Ashokan treaty existed (Ashoka came two generations later), and the Nanda soldiers were not his by birthright; he had to overthrow the Nandas, not inherit their loyalty.

19. (B) Chandragupta seized power by toppling the hated Nanda dynasty, aided by the strategist Kautilya. Alexander did not crown him; the throne could not be inherited from

Ashoka, who was Chandragupta's own grandson and ruled much later; and the chapter does not credit a Persian marriage. The trap reverses the family order and invents foreign backing.

20. (A) Kautilya is the same person as Chanakya, also called Vishnugupta, the author of the Arthashastra. Megasthenes was the Greek envoy who later visited the Mauryan court, Panini was a grammarian, and Porus was the northwestern king Alexander fought. Only Chanakya/Vishnugupta names Kautilya himself.

21. (B) Kautilya's Arthashastra is a manual of how to run a state: administration, policy, economy and strategy. It is not a religious text, not praise-poetry, and not a gathering of edicts; Ashoka's edicts came later and were carved on stone, not authored by Kautilya. The word artha pointing to wealth and worldly affairs signals its practical, governing focus.

22. (B) The seven limbs are the king, the ministers, the territory with its people, the fort, the treasury, the army and the allies. The other lists mix up social classes, geographical features or military assets, none of which match Kautilya's seven elements of a functioning state.

23. (B) The body analogy is the point: just as a body fails if one organ is weak, a state falters if any limb such as the treasury, army or allies is neglected, so all must function together. The choice is not about lucky numbers, and there was no rule barring the king from a treasury or from commanding troops; those inventions miss Kautilya's integrated view of the state.

24. (C) The treasury and army are listed apart because they do different jobs: the treasury provides resources, the army provides force and protection. They were of course used together, the treasury in fact paid the army, and the treasury was the state's, not the guilds'. Distinct functions, not separation in use or ownership, is why they are two limbs.

25. (A) Chandragupta founded the empire, Kautilya was his mentor and wrote the Arthashastra, and Megasthenes was the Greek ambassador who described the Mauryan court. The other orderings shuffle these roles, for instance making Chandragupta the Greek visitor or Kautilya the last Nanda king, which scramble the well-known identities.

26. (C) Megasthenes wrote the Indica, a foreign eyewitness description of Mauryan society and government that historians still draw on. He did not write the Arthashastra, that was Kautilya; he did not carve Ashoka's much later edicts; and he founded no dynasty. His worth lies in his outside observer's record.

27. (D) Bindusara was Chandragupta's son and Ashoka's father, the middle ruler of the three great Mauryas. He was not Kautilya the mentor-author, nor the Greek envoy Megasthenes, nor the dynasty's founder, who was Chandragupta. Placing him in the line between Chandragupta and Ashoka is the key fact.

28. (B) The Mauryas organised the realm into provinces under governors and a body of officials reporting to the centre, so the emperor's authority reached far without his presence. Villages were not left wholly independent, guilds governed crafts rather than provinces, and no emperor could literally visit every village yearly. Administration through officials is the mechanism.

29. (D) Dhamma-mahamatras were Ashoka's officers charged with promoting and supervising his code of moral conduct. They were not frontier cavalry commanders, not tribute collectors, and not stone-carvers; their distinctive duty was the propagation of Dhamma, reflecting Ashoka's use of administration to carry his ethical message.

30. (A) Spies gave the emperor information from afar, including whether his officials and provinces were loyal and orderly, helping him rule a vast realm. They did not make the army unnecessary, had nothing to do with currency, and did not replace governors; intelligence supplemented administration rather than substituting for these other supports.

31. (B) Taxes furnished the regular income that funded the army, the officials and public works, the lifeblood of the state. Taxation was a normal source of revenue, not chiefly a punishment; it filled the state treasury rather than the guilds' coffers; and far from replacing the economy, it depended on a thriving one to yield revenue.

32. (B) Ashoka's empire covered almost all of the subcontinent except the southern tip of the peninsula. The Ganga plains held the capital Pataliputra, the northwest extending toward Afghanistan was firmly inside, and the east toward modern Bangladesh was included too. The far south stayed outside Mauryan control.

33. (C) Ashoka's transformative war was the conquest of Kalinga, in present-day Odisha, whose carnage led him toward Dhamma. The Persians were Alexander's earlier foe, Porus was defeated by Alexander, and the Nandas were overthrown by Chandragupta a generation before Ashoka. Only Kalinga marks Ashoka's turning point.

34. (C) The motive for the Kalinga war was conquest and expansion; only after witnessing the suffering it caused did Ashoka embrace Dhamma, so cause and effect run the opposite way from the student's claim. Kalinga's prior religion was not the reason, the war certainly happened, and there was no blanket religious ban that the claim relies on. The trap is reversing the order of events.

35. (A) Ashoka's own edicts confess his sorrow over the slaughter at Kalinga, giving us his remorse in his own words. Megasthenes wrote before Ashoka's reign and the Indica does not cover Kalinga; Kautilya's Arthashastra likewise predates Ashoka; and a later commemorative temple is not the evidence the chapter cites. His edicts are the direct testimony.

36. (B) Dhamma was a broad ethical code urging honesty, non-violence, tolerance and dutiful conduct, addressed to all subjects whatever their faith. It was not a new religion replacing Buddhism, not a tax, and certainly not a doctrine of war. Ashoka used it to bind his peoples morally rather than to found a creed or fund the state.

37. (C) Ashoka carved his messages into rocks and pillars set up throughout the empire, a durable and public means of reaching many people. He did not rely on soldiers reciting them, printing did not yet exist, and a single central temple would have reached few. The wide network of inscribed edicts is what earns him the title.

38. (B) Choosing stone made the messages lasting and openly visible for generations, which is exactly why so many survive to be read today. Cost was not the driver, writing surfaces other than paper existed, and Brahmi was not restricted to stone; it could be written by other means. Permanence and public visibility explain the choice.

39. (C) Most of Ashoka's edicts use the everyday Prakrit language set down in the Brahmi script. They were not in Sanskrit and Devanagari, nor in Greek and Latin, and although Brahmi is correct as a script, the everyday spoken language used was Prakrit rather than Tamil. Pairing the right language with the right script is the test here.

40. (D) A language is what people speak; a script is the set of signs used to write it. Prakrit was spoken and Brahmi was the writing system, so they belong to different categories. Swapping the two, calling both Greek scripts, or denying that either is a script all repeat or worsen the classic confusion. Language and script are not the same kind of thing.

41. (A) Prakrit was the language of common speech, so using it let Ashoka's words reach ordinary subjects rather than only the learned. Sanskrit already existed, any language can be inscribed on stone, and Prakrit was the popular rather than a secret tongue. Reaching the common people is why everyday Prakrit suited his purpose.

42. (A) Brahmi is the parent script from which many later Indian writing systems evolved, giving it deep significance in the history of writing in India. It is not the Roman alphabet, it has in fact been deciphered, and it is a script, not a spoken court language. Its role as the root of later Indian scripts is the key point.

43. (C) India adopted the Lion Capital that once crowned Ashoka's pillar at Sarnath as its national emblem. The Sanchi stupa and the Dhauili elephant are other famous Mauryan-era works but were not chosen as the emblem, and the dancing terracotta figure belongs to a different, earlier context. Only the Sarnath Lion Capital became the emblem.

44. (D) In architecture a capital is the sculpted top of a column, here the four-lion piece that crowned the Sarnath pillar. It does not mean the empire's capital city, its treasury, or an edict; those would confuse the architectural term with political or textual ones. The capital is the head of the column.

45. (D) Sarnath was hallowed as the site of the Buddha's first sermon, a fitting place for Ashoka to set up a pillar. It was not his coronation site, not the battlefield of Kalinga (which lay in Odisha), and not where Chandragupta beat the Nandas (Magadha). Its Buddhist sanctity is why Ashoka chose it.

46. (C) The dharmachakra stands for the wheel of dharma, the path of righteous conduct and the Buddha's teaching, taken from the Sarnath capital. It is not a war-chariot wheel, a map of trade routes, or a sun symbol; its meaning is moral and spiritual, reflecting the values Ashoka promoted.

47. (D) The Nandas rose first in the fifth century BCE, Alexander arrived about 326 BCE, Chandragupta founded the Maurya empire about 321 BCE, and Ashoka's Kalinga war came later in the third century BCE. The orderings that put Alexander or Chandragupta before the Nandas, or Chandragupta before Alexander, break the established sequence.

48. (A) The Nandas were the first to weld Magadha into a large unified power, and the Mauryas then displaced them and pushed the empire across most of the subcontinent. The Mauryas, not the Nandas, built the great empire; only Ashoka of the Mauryas carved edicts; and the two were successive, not simultaneous rivals.

49. (A) A satrap was a provincial governor appointed to administer a region for the ruler who had conquered it. It is not a payment of tribute, not a moneylenders' guild, and not a bodyguard. The satrap is an official, which is why weak satraps left by Alexander could later be absorbed by Chandragupta.

50. (D) A tributary is a defeated king who keeps his own throne in exchange for tribute, while a satrap is simply an official appointed to govern a province, owning no kingdom of his own. The first distractor swaps the two definitions; tributaries do not outrank the overlord; and neither role is fixed by ethnicity. Throne-holder versus appointee is the distinction.

51. (A) From 232 BCE to about 185 BCE is roughly forty-seven years, so the empire fell within about half a century of Ashoka's death, showing how fast it unravelled once its great ruler was gone. Two centuries, one year, or over three hundred years all misjudge that gap. The swift decline is itself a lesson about the fragility of empires.

52. (C) Empires are held together by force and the flow of tribute; when the central power weakens, far provinces seize the chance to break free, which is why even the greatest empires fall. They were in fact very large, did keep armies, and did collect tribute, so those statements are simply false. Dependence on a strong centre is the root of fragility.

53. (A) Rebellion is likeliest when central authority slackens under a weak ruler and the burden of tribute rises, giving both opportunity and grievance. A succession of strong emperors keeps provinces in check, lighter tribute and peace reduce discontent, and better

roads strengthen the centre's reach. Weak centre plus heavy demands is the danger combination.

54. (B) Patronage of art and learning fosters a common culture that unites diverse subjects, so neglecting it leaves an empire culturally loose even when materially strong. Tribute, soldiers and forts depend on the army, economy and administration the empire still has, so those would not vanish. The missing support specifically weakens cultural cohesion.

55. (B) Ashoka's remorse over Kalinga is what turned him from conquest to Dhamma; without it he would likely have continued warring and never issued the moral edicts. The empire would not have fallen instantly, Brahmi's much later decipherment is unrelated, and Chandragupta, who ruled generations earlier, could not be affected. Remove the remorse and you remove the Dhamma edicts.

56. (A) Because the edicts were placed across Ashoka's lands, mapping where they are found traces the reach of his empire and influence. They do not record Alexander's birth year, market iron prices, or guild counts; those are not what the inscriptions convey. The geographic spread is the historian's clue to the empire's extent.

57. (C) The chapter's overarching message is the difficulty of holding an empire together, which is why even mighty ones like the Mauryas declined after their strongest rulers. Empires do not last forever, a lone strong emperor is not enough without the other supports, and tribute alone cannot rule without an army and administration. The fragility and effort of maintenance is the lesson.

58. (D) Although Alexander beat Porus, his exhausted troops mutinied against advancing deeper into India, and that refusal forced the turn for home. Chandragupta did not defeat him, the Nandas did not buy him off, and it was not a simple shortage of weapons; the soldiers' unwillingness to go on is the immediate reason recorded for his withdrawal.

59. (A) Officials extended the emperor's reach across regions he could never personally oversee, turning a vast territory into something governable. They did not make the army or treasury redundant, since an empire still needed force and funds; they did not abolish taxes, which they actually helped collect; and their role was administration, not court poetry. Bridging distance is why administration was essential.

60. (D) The Indica is a foreign envoy's description of Mauryan India, whereas the edicts are Ashoka's own public messages carved in stone, so one is an outsider's report and the other a ruler's direct statement. The Indica is not scripture and the edicts are not poetry; the edicts used Prakrit in Brahmi rather than Greek; and neither founded nor ended the empire. Outsider account versus the ruler's own voice is the key contrast.